

Strategic Plan

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Strategic Plan

Mission

The University of Maryland’s School of Public Policy pursues a three part mission:

- 1. Developing diverse and innovative leaders in the art and science of policy and governance;
- 2. Advancing the frontiers of applied interdisciplinary knowledge; and
- 3. Promoting local, state, national, and global public good.

Values

We are guided by and model these values in practice:

- We hold that serving the public good is at the heart of our identity as a land-grant institution as well as our academic mission;
- We are committed to upholding and advancing democratic governance;
- We believe that multi-stakeholder governance encompassing the public, private, and nonprofit spheres is essential for advancing the public good;
- We embrace diversity, equity, and inclusion as a community and as a critical component of the development and implementation of good policy; and
- We recognize that policy and governance is not just a technical exercise, but one that is imbued with ethics and normative values.

Headwinds and tailwinds in higher education and public policy

As we look to the next five years and chart a course for the School, we must be cognizant of the challenges facing higher education broadly and the field of public policy specifically, and the opportunities that exist to support our goals.

Headwinds

Increasing economic pressure on students

Against a rising cost of education and stagnating wages and job opportunities in the public sphere, a growing pressure to go into other fields with higher income potential threatens to limit the pool of applicants for our programs. In addition, specifically at the graduate level, our enrollments are depressed during periods where there are robust job markets and positive economic outlooks. Growing the applicant pool will require us to not only consider the quality and relevance of our programs on an ongoing basis but also address changing needs for delivery to keep costs down. Raising additional support for prospective students will be critical for a vibrant and growing student body.

Increasing economic pressure on public institutions of higher education, and a rapidly evolving business model

Revenue pressures from multiple angles are resulting in a rapid evolution of the higher education business model. Higher education across the country is facing flat or declining public funding, with possible future pressures to reduce funding, potentially dramatically. While the state of Maryland has continued to provide strong levels of public funding relative to many other states, prudence requires us to be ready to address possible shifts in the policy and budget environment that could cause downward pressure on this funding. Other traditional avenues to bolster resources, including tuition increases and international student growth, are respectively constrained by growing student debt and an increasingly competitive environment for public policy programs outside the United States.

Political polarization and tarnished perceptions of higher education and public service

Societal trust in and support for higher education in the United States is at historic lows, with only half of adults thinking that colleges and universities have a positive effect on the direction of the country. There is a strong partisan dimension to these views, with almost 60% of those identifying as Republicans or independents who lean Republican believe that higher education has a negative effect on the way things are going in the United States. Within the field of public policy, sustained attacks on the role of government, and on government and public service professionals, is contributing to a decline in the attractiveness of careers in public policy. Maintaining a broad support base for public service and schools that prepare professionals for public service is essential in the years ahead.

A rapidly shifting policy education landscape

A proliferation of options for graduate policy degrees, including highly specialized and niche policy degrees, as well as accelerated degrees targeted at specific working populations, is changing the face of the traditional graduate policy degree field and making it ever more competitive. Likewise, well-resourced alternatives including professional STEM and business degrees are creating an increasingly

competitive marketplace for potential students. Policy issues related to science and technology are emerging at the forefront of the field, with a need to prepare graduates with both technical and policy literacy. At the same time, perhaps the greatest change to the policy education space is the fact that policy is increasingly becoming a subject for undergraduate study, including a rapid growth of programs offering undergraduate majors. These competitive pressures are occurring at the same time higher education in the United States is expected to experience slower growth of the postsecondary student population, with projected annual growth in degree conferrals at all levels falling below 0.5% through 2027 (from an average annual growth of 2.5% between 2007 and 2017).

Tailwinds

Our location affords us access to all levels of policymaking, exposure to a diverse range of issues, and engagement with the full spectrum of policy and governance institutions, organizations, and actors

Our proximity to the federal government in Washington, DC, the state government in Annapolis, and the local governments of Prince George's and Montgomery counties presents opportunities to access policy making at all levels. Further, the concentration of private, nonprofit, and intergovernmental organizations in the region, addressing both domestic and international concerns, affords a breadth and depth of exposure to policy expertise and debates available to few other policy schools.

Situated within a top-tier public research university

As a policy school located within a large and active public research university, we have a broad and deep set of potential partners at our disposal. In particular, the University's strengths in science and technology, including cyber, artificial intelligence, data, and sustainability, present opportunities to expand our activities by leveraging existing resources.

Positive relationships and strong linkages with the state of Maryland

A continued history of strong state support for higher education in Maryland, including current support for the School of Public Policy, is a valuable and rare asset. In addition, the School has numerous constructive relationships with the state, both through academic and research programs in support of the state and through the positions our alums hold in the executive and legislative branches.

An increasingly attractive and accessible location

With the redevelopment of College Park and Baltimore Avenue, and the completion of the Purple Line light rail, the University stands to evolve from its history as a commuter institution to both a dynamic college town and a more integrated part of the DC region. These developments offer the opportunity to better

link our community not only to Washington, DC, but to College Park and Prince George’s and Montgomery counties, and to attract students, faculty, and staff.

Value for money

As a publicly-supported, nationally-recognized policy school in a top-tier university, we provide a high-quality education at a lower cost compared to most competitor institutions. To take advantage of this tailwind, we will need to raise additional scholarship/fellowship support to remain highly competitive in the value for money category.

Goal 1 - Pursue continued growth and strengthen connections across our programs and our community

Recognizing the imperative of growth to meet increasing and evolving needs in the public policy sphere, to serve as a critical and necessary source of resources to sustain and expand our activities, and to advance the state and public mission of the School, we will pursue balanced and integrated growth.

Program growth and integration	⊕
Recruitment and program offerings	⊕
Faculty	⊕
Alumni engagement	⊕
Resourcing our growth	⊕

Goal 2 - Build an increasingly diverse and inclusive school with a strong sense of belonging for all

Recognizing the importance of diversity and inclusion as the fabric of our society, and essential in educating diverse policy leaders, developing inclusive research, and addressing a broad range of policy issues, we will build an increasingly diverse and inclusive school that creates a strong sense of belonging for all.

Student recruitment and admissions	⊕
Faculty recruitment and retention	⊕
Curriculum	⊕
Training and development	⊕
Building community	⊕

Goal 3 - Establish the School of Public Policy as a top policy school with a distinctive identity

Recognizing an increasingly competitive marketplace for students and resources, with pressure from peer institutions and alternatives to the policy field, we must maintain the core strengths of a leading policy school while investing in existing assets and new areas to develop and maintain a captivating approach to policy education, research, and impact.

Core strengths of a quality policy education	⊕
A community of scholars and practitioners	⊕
Governance across sectoral, jurisdictional, and geographic boundaries	⊕
In service of the public good	⊕
Building ourselves into campus	⊕

Goal 4 - Build recognized strength within and between key substantive focus areas

Recognizing that a focus on a defined number of areas builds the depth of activity that allows for recognized strength and the attraction of faculty, students, and resources, we will

integrate and coordinate teaching, research, and impact activities within and between six key areas.

International and Global Policy	⊕
Leadership, Management, and Finance	⊕
Philanthropy and Nonprofit Leadership	⊕
Science, Technology, and Policy	⊕
Social Policy	⊕
Sustainability	⊕
Building strength at the intersections	⊕

Goal 5 - Expand research activity within the School to enhance our prominence and impact in and on the field

Recognizing that a robust research profile increases the School’s impact and prominence, provides additional resources, and enhances the ability to recruit faculty and students, we will expand our research activity.

A robust research active faculty	⊕
Collaborative Research	⊕
Student participation	⊕
Recognized excellence	⊕
Support and projection	⊕



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